



LAKSHYA KEEPS FINDING A WAY

At one point, Indian badminton star Lakshya Sen's Olympic qualification looked uncertain, but he seems to have **regained his form just in time.**

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Over the past week at the All England Championships, thanks to his decision to swap half-sleeved T-shirts for sleeveless ones, Lakshya Sen's love of ink has been getting more airtime. On the skin of his left deltoid are a couple of tattoos that read 'Believe' and 'Never Give Up'. That's been the theme for Lakshya over the last fortnight.

When he headed into the French Open at the start of March, the 22-year-old seemed to be treading water. In a streak that began last August, he had never made it past the first round in eight tournaments as he racked up a dismal 3-11 record. Ranked 12th in the world in July last

year, the extended plunge in form saw him nearly fall off the top 20 rankings by the start of February 2024. **The dip had even seemed to follow him in domestic competition; he lost to unheralded Bharat Raghav in the quarterfinals of the national championships.**

A temporary slump might be something most athletes take in their stride. But in this Olympic year, where only the top 16 of the world are guaranteed qualification for the Paris Games in July, there was the very real possibility that the former world bronze medallist, who was once considered one of India's best bets at the Olympics, might not even make the cut.

But when it mattered the most, Lakshya seems to have rediscovered



For a player who's no stranger to success at the international level and who has made the final at All England previously, a semifinal finish left Lakshya a little unsatisfied.